

ARE WE COMMITTED TO BUILDING BETTER STREETS THAT BOOST CYCLING TRANSPORT?

A POLICY CONTENT ANALYSIS OF VICTORIA'S POLICIES

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INTRODUCTION

Car-dependency presents a complex and pervasive public health challenge for our growing cities. Private car travel is a major contributor to greenhouse gas emissions, traffic congestion, air and noise pollution and physical inactivity [1]. Globally, over a million people die every year in road transport related accidents, and 20–50 million more are injured [2]. Switching to sustainable and active modes of transport, such as cycling, has the potential to address these issues simultaneously. In Australia, only 1-2% of journeys are taken by bike, while almost 70% of trips under 5km are taken by private car in Greater Melbourne [3].

The built environment is one of the primary determinants of cycling transport [4]. International and national organisations recommend re-designing the built environment so that cycling transport is attractive, convenient, and given priority over motorised transport. While state and local governments in Victoria recognise the importance of cycling transport, little action has been taken to improve the cyclability of our streets.

Therefore, with a focus on Local Governments Areas within Metropolitan Melbourne, the aims of this study are to:

- 1) explore the use of built environment actions or interventions,
- 2) evaluate commitment to implementation and evidence used to support policies, and;
- 3) determine if cycling transport is integrated across a range of policy domains.

METHODS

A deductive-inductive content analysis of policy documents was completed. In the absence of a suitable analysis tool, an evidence-informed list of interventions was collected and applied to policy documents. Two local councils from each of the five metropolitan regions in Melbourne were selected. Publicly available documents relating to council plans, health and wellbeing, transport, urban planning, accessibility, sustainability, housing and land use, structure plans and budgets were collected from each council website. Documents were then screened to determine the level at which cycling transport was considered and integrated into the policy. Documents were excluded from the analysis if they only mentioned cycling transport rather

than presenting tangible actions, if they addressed only soft/social interventions or only recreational cycling.

RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

The results of this study will identify and compare 1) the frequency and diversity of built environment actions / interventions, 2) the intent of actions / interventions, 3) the frequency of implementation instruments and the type and frequency of evidence used to support proposed interventions. Policy strengths, gaps and challenges will be identified. Finally, the integration of cycling transport across policy domains will be determined and compared across local councils. Understanding policy content and quality will provide insight into how policy current supports or restricts political prioritisation and action towards improving street design to support cycling transport.

CONCLUSIONS

This research will identify the strengths, gaps and inconsistencies in how Victorian local governments propose to support cycling transport through the built environment. Understanding the quality, quantity, intent and integration of these cycling transport policies offers insight into the degree of political prioritisation given to active transport. Highlighting where current policy may fall short of addressing the changes needed to transition people from cars to active transport can inform targeted policy improvement across councils in Metropolitan Melbourne. These findings contribute to the broader effort to address the climate, health, environmental and social challenges that current car-dependent transport practices compound.

REFERENCES

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